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**The second most powerful executive at the company, Sheryl Sandberg, says experiments were 'poorly communicated'**



Facebook's Sheryl Sandberg apologises for poor communication over psychological experiments. Photograph: Money Sharma/EPA Photograph: MONEY SHARMA/EPA

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Facebook's first public comment on the experiments came as the social network attempted to woo Indian advertisers as part of its efforts to tailor adverts to users outside of the US. The aim of the government-sponsored

study was to see whether positive or negative words in messages would lead to positive or negative content in status updates.

The company's researchers decided after tweaking the content of peoples' "news feeds" that there was "emotional contagion" across the social network, by which people who saw one emotion being expressed would themselves express similar emotions.

"We take privacy and security at Facebook really seriously because that is something that allows people to share" opinions and emotions, said Sandberg.

The UK data protection watchdog, the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO), [is investigating the experiment](#) to determine whether Facebook has infringed on UK law.

The social network also [faced stern criticism from commentators](#) and researchers, over its handling of the experiment which was not explained to users and therefore was performed without their permission, with some referring to it as "creepy", "evil", "terrifying" and "super disturbing".

Facebook later [added a "research" policy to its terms and conditions](#), four months after the experiment took place.

[If Facebook can tweak our emotions and make us vote, what else can it do?](#)

### At this unsettling time

We hope you appreciated this article. Before you close this tab, we want to ask if you could support the Guardian at this crucial time for journalism in the US.

In his first presidency, Donald Trump called journalists the enemy; a year into his second term, it's clear that this time around, he's treating us like one.

From Hungary to Russia, authoritarian regimes have made silencing independent media one of their defining moves. Sometimes outright censorship isn't even required to achieve this goal. In the United States, we have seen the administration apply various forms of pressure on news outlets in the year since Trump returned to office. One of our great disappointments is how quickly some of the most storied US media organizations have folded when faced with the mere specter of hostility from the administration - long before their hand was forced.

While private news organizations can choose how to respond to this government's threats, insults and lawsuits, public media has been powerless to stop the defunding of federally supported television and radio. This has been devastating for local and rural communities, who stand to lose not only their primary source of local news and cultural programming, but health and public safety information, including emergency alerts.

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